



■ By Ashok K. Damodaran in New York

Of the two events that happened in New York starting September 23, one dominated the news pages and the other captured the imagination of New Yorkers. President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad of Iran arrived in the city to attend the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) and was greeted by headlines like "The Evil Has Landed". The same morning, more than a million-and-half New Yorkers woke up to a full-page exhortation in *The New York Times*, asking the city's denizens to "experience India in New York". If the first was a reflection of the city's response to a man most Americans love to hate, the second provided the perfect springboard for an incredible and spontaneous response to an Indian initiative to reach out to American hearts and wallets.

The IncredibleIndia road show—rechristened IncredibleIndia@60—in the world's financial capital, jointly sponsored by the Ministry of Tourism and the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), was meant to showcase India's stunning tourism assets, its high-growth economy and its democratic credentials. Tourism Minister Ambika Soni was to inaugurate the event, but could not make it, and

THE GREAT INDIAN INVITATION

India went all out to woo American hearts and wallets with a four-day cultural extravaganza that left New Yorkers asking for more



External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram, Commerce Minister Kamal Nath, Overseas Indians' Affairs Minister Vayalar Ravi and a few chief ministers, filled in at the grand inaugural at the 2,700-seater Lincoln Centre. Over the next three days, as the events unfolded across Manhattan, it was clear the newly-renewed friendship between the two countries was matched by the warmth of the New Yorkers, who also embraced India.

Never has the influence of India been more obvious. Scores of public transport buses were given a tricolour coating. From Times Square to Fifth Avenue, advertisements hung on lamp posts and huge billboards announced the arrival of IncredibleIndia. And at